

URBANIZATION AND DEVELOPMENT

Definition of terms:

b) *Urbanization*. The process of transition from a rural to a more urban society. Statistically, urbanization reflects an increasing proportion of the population living in settlements defined as urban, primarily through net rural to urban migration. The level of urbanization is the percentage of the total population living in towns and cities while the rate of urbanization is the rate at which it grows.

c) *Urban growth*. The increase in the number of people who live in towns and cities, and the amount of land devoted to urban places.

e) *The urban transition*. The passage from a predominantly rural to a predominantly urban society.

Urbanization is increasing in both the developed and developing countries. However, rapid urbanization, particularly the growth of large cities, and the associated problems of unemployment, poverty, inadequate health, poor sanitation, urban slums and environmental degradation pose a formidable challenge in many developing countries.

Available statistics show that more than half of the world's 6.6 billion people live in urban areas, crowded into 3 percent of the earth's land area (Angotti, 1993; UNFPA, 1993). By 2030 this number will swell to almost 5 billion, with urban growth concentrated in Africa and Asia. While mega-cities have captured much public attention, most of the new growth will occur in smaller towns and cities, which have fewer resources to respond to the magnitude of the change UNFPA 2007).

More than 90 percent of future population growth will be concentrated in cities in developing countries and a large percentage of this population will be poor. In Africa and Asia where urbanization is still considerably lower (40 percent), both are expected to be 54 percent urban by 2025 (UN 1995; 2002).

Although urbanization is the driving force for modernization, economic growth and development, there is increasing concern about the effects of expanding cities, principally on human health, livelihoods and the environment. The implications of rapid urbanization and demographic trends for employment, food security, water supply, shelter and sanitation, especially the disposal of wastes (solid and liquid) that the cities produce are staggering (UNCED, 1992).

The question that arises is whether the current trend in urban growth is sustainable considering the accompanying urban challenges such as unemployment, slum development, poverty and environmental degradation, especially in the developing countries (PERN 2003).

The urbanization process

One significant feature of the urbanization process in Africa is that unlike Europe and Asia much of the growth is taking place in the absence of significant industrial expansion. Mega cities defined as cities with 10 million inhabitants are few. Urbanization also finds expression

principally in outward expansion of the built up area and conversion of prime agricultural lands into residential and industrial uses.

Urbanization process is also driven by government development policies and budget allocations which favour urban residents over rural areas.

Causes of urbanization in Africa

- i) Natural increase fuelled by improved medical care, better sanitation and improved food supplies which reduce death rates and cause population growth.
- ii) Rural urban migration due to:

Pull factors: In many developing countries, rural poverty drives people from rural areas to the city in search of better lives (employment, education, food, shelter etc)

Push factors: In Africa, most people move into urban centers because they are pushed by factors such as environmental degradation, conflict, religious strife, political persecution, food insecurity, lack of basic infrastructure and services (water, sanitation, housing, hospitals, electricity, hospitals etc)

Effects of urbanization

Although, cities serve as ‘engines’ of growth in most developing countries by providing opportunities for employment, education, knowledge and technology transfer and ready markets for industrial and agricultural products, high urban populations place enormous stress on natural resources and imposes ‘ecological footprints’ on the peri-urban areas (Rees, 1992; Rees and Wackernagel, 1994).

The conversion of farm lands and watersheds for residential purposes have negative consequences on food security, water supply as well as the health of the people, both in the cities and in the peri-urban areas.

Social effects

- i. The influx of people into urban areas has not been accompanied by an increase in the provision of certain amenities and as a result, health care facilities, educational institutions, water and sewerage facilities, electricity, housing has not matched the demand. As a result there is a lot of pressure that has created a ripple effect to certain illicit activities. There is an increase in crime, drug-peddling, prostitution and street families as a result of the pressures described above.
- ii. Cities impact on health in many ways. In the areas of the environment and health, problems of emission reduction, supply of clean drinking water, sewage and rubbish disposal, food security and poverty reduction are the most important. Vulnerability of the urban population to natural disasters and diseases, especially HIV/AIDS and atmospheric pollution has also been recognized. Although, data about pollution levels are fragmentary, the air and water quality in many cities threatens the health of millions of city residents (UNEP, 1994).

- iii) Urban populations are vulnerable to natural disasters and diseases like malaria and those associated with pollution due to congestion.
- iv) Cultivation of crops through sewerage irrigation and use of chemical pesticides affect the health of consumers who are notified of the consequences of cultivation of these products.

Economic effects

- i) Land has become more unavailable and scarce with the growth of industries and mushrooming of residential areas. As a result slums arise in congested areas leading to social problems like crime, water borne diseases and STD's.
- ii) Exploitation of the unskilled workers. Most of the unskilled workers are paid meagre salaries which is not able to provide the basic amenities and as result engage in illegal activities.
- iii) Creation of small and medium scale industries. The jua-kali sector has sprawled with the increase of urbanization.
- iv) Loss of property rights as a result of people being unable to pay the normal royalties and rights. The black market has thrived and this undercuts the tax amounts which the government should be reaping.
- v) Growth of cartels in different sectors for example the matatu industry, textile and others.
- vi) A large proportion of the urban population is also affected by poor sanitation that threatens their health. River pollution is particularly found to be worse where rivers pass through cities and the most widespread is contamination from human excreta, sewage and oxygen loss (UNEP 986). It is estimated that about 400 million people or about one-third of the population in the developing countries do not have safe drinking water (World Bank, 1990).

Technological effects

- i) Increase in innovation as a result of the increase in small scale industries for example the jua-kali industry. Formation of middle-men and commercial attaches who provide a promise to market the urban goods to other areas.

Characteristics of migrants

Groups of migrants often differ from other groups in such characteristics as sex composition, age, and marital status.

Sex composition.

Within developing countries, a growing share of rural-to-urban migrants is women, especially younger women. Women are beginning to comprise most of the flow to cities in Africa, a reversal of earlier patterns in the region.

The trend reflects both the lack of jobs in rural areas and the increasing availability of jobs for women created by the labor-intensive manufacturing operations of multinational corporations. Also, many female migrants, particularly the young and single, work as domestics and in other service jobs available in large cities.

Age

Most migrant populations are young. Migration among women tends to peak at ages 15 to 24. Young women usually find it easier than older women to migrate because there are more jobs and because they have not yet married and established families. A second, smaller age

peak occurs at around age 45. However, women in their forties may be able to migrate more readily than women in their late 20s or 30s. Their family ties may have weakened after their children have grown, and they may also be widowed or divorced.

Marital status

The marital status of rural-to-urban migrant women varies widely by country, and there appears to be no pattern. In Kenya, Senegal and Mali many migrants are single women. In some African cities a substantial percentage of recent female migrants are unmarried or married but not living with their husbands. In other countries of Africa such as Ghana and Tanzania, married women are more likely than single women to migrate from the countryside to cities. Unmarried migrant women often marry once they settle in new places.

Level of education

There is a definite relationship between education attainment and migration. People with more years of schooling are more likely to migrate than those with fewer.

Economic status

For many years, the largest percentages of urban migrants were poor, landless and unskilled individuals.

In colonial Africa, migrants were from various income levels seeking short-term urban jobs

Today, with the emergence of a modern industrial sector in most urban areas, Migrants are both males and females of all socioeconomic strata, with a majority of them being very poor because most rural inhabitants are poor.